

Agatha Christie

THE

SECRET OF

CHIMNEYS

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his is the story of ;
beautiful and capti-
vating woman who
no man could re-
sist—who learned
(nearly too late) that
such charm can be
fatal.

Chapter One

Anthony Cade Signs

“Gentleman Joe!”

“Why, if it isn’t old Jimmy McGrath. f ‘ Castle’s Select Tour, represented by seven depressed looking females and three perspiring males, looked on with considerable interest. Evidently their Mr. Cade had met an ~ old friend. They all admired Mr. Cade so much, his tall _ lean figure, his sun-tanned face, the light-hearted manner with which he settled disputes and cajoled them all into good temper. This friend of his now—surely rather a peculiar-looking man. About the same height as Mr. Cade, but thickset and not nearly so good-looking. The sort of man one read about in books, who probably kept a saloon. Interesting, though. After all, that was what one came abroad for—to see all these peculiar things one read about in books. Up to now, they had been rather bored with Bulawayo. The sun was unbearably hot, the hotel was uncomfortable, there seemed to be nowhere particular to go until the moment should arrive to motor to the Matoppos. Very fortunately, Mr. Cade had suggested picture post-cards. There was an excellent supply of picture postcards.

Anthony Cade and his friend had stepped a little apart. “What the hell are you doing with this pack of females?”

demanded McGrath. “Starting a harem?”

“Not with this little lot,” grinned Anthony. “Have you taken a good look at them?” “T have that. Thought maybe you were losing your eye-

“My eyesight’s as good as ever it was. No, this is a

Castle’s Select Tour. I’m Castle—the local Castle, I mean.”

“What the hell made you take on a job like that?” “A regrettable necessity for cash. I can assure you it doesn’t suit my temperament.” ar Jimmy grinned. “Never a hog for regular work, were you?”
a enrnony ignored this aspersion.

“However, something with turn ‘up soon, I I expect” he remarked hopefully. “It usually does.” —

Jimmy chuckled. “If there’s any trouble tip Anthony Cade is sure to be in it sooner or later, I know that,” he said. “You’ve an absolute instinct for rows—and the nine lives of a cat. When can we have a yarn together?”

Anthony sighed. “T’ ve got to take these cackling. hens to see Rhodes’s grave.”

“That’s the stuff,” said Jimmy approvingly. “They’ll come back bumped black and blue with the ruts in the road, and clamoring for béd to rest the bruises on. Then you and J will have a spot and exchange the news.” |

“Right. So long, Jimmy.”

Anthony rejoined his flock of sheep. Miss Taylor, the youngest and most skittish of the party, instantly attacked him. “Oh, Mr. Cade, was that an old friend of yours?” _

“Tt was Miss Taylor. One of the friends of my blameless. youth.” Miss Taylor giggled. “I thought he was such an interesting-looking man.”

“PH tell him you said so.” a

“Oh, Mr: Cade, how can you be so naughty! The ery idea! What was that name he called you?” } 4

“Gentleman Joe?” Be.

“Yes. Is your name Joe?” :

“{ thought you knew it was Anthony, Miss Taylor.”

“Oh, go on with you!” cried Miss Taylor couuetien

Anthony had by now well mastered his duties. Tn addt, tion to making the necessary arrangements of travel, ‘they included soothing down irritable old gentlemen when their dignity was ruffled, seeing that elderly matrons had ample opportunities to buy picture postcards, and flirting with everything under a catholic forty years of age. The last task was rendered easier for him by the extreme readiness of the ladies in question to read a tender meaning a ps most innocent remarks.

Miss Taylor returned to the attack. “Why does’ Re, cal as you Joe, then?” Mi

“Oh, just because it isn’t my name.”

“And why Gentleman Joe?”

“The | same kind of reason.”

“Oh, Mr. Cade,” protested Miss Taylor, much distressed, _ “T’m sure you shouldn’t say that. Papa was saying only _ last night what gentlemanly manners you had.”

_ * “Very kind of your father, I’m sure, Miss Taylor.”

_ “And we are all agreed that you are quite the gentle-

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He marshaled the rest of the party in the direction of. the café. Miss Taylor kept by his side, and resumed her catechism. “Is it a long time since you saw your friend?” “Just over seven years.”

“Was it in Africa you knew him?”

“Yes, not this part though. The first time I ever saw Jimmy McGrath, he was all trussed up ready for the cook-ing pot. Some of the tribes in the interior are cannibals, you know. We got there just in time.”

“What happened?”

“Very nice little shindy. We potted some of the beggars, and the rest took to their heels.”

“Oh, Mr. Cade, what an adventurous life you must have led!”

“Very peaceful, I assure you.”

But it was clear that the lady did not believe him.

It was about ten o’clock that night when Anthony Cade walked into the small room where Jimmy McGrath was | busy manipulating various bottles. “Make it strong, James,” | — he implored. “I can tell you, I need it.”

“T should think you did, my boy. I wouldn’t take on that job of yours for anything. %»

“Show me another, and I’ll jump out of it fast enough. f

McGrath poured out his own drink, tossed it off with a practiced hand, and mixed a second one. Then he com slowly, “Are you in earnest about that, old son?”

“About what?”

“Chuckling this job of yours if you could get another?”

“Why? You don’t mean to say that you’ve got a ew going begging? Why don’t you grab it yourse ee

“I have grabbed it—but I don’t much fancy it, That’s why I’m trying to pass it on to you.”

Anthony became suspicious.’ “What’s wrong with ra . They haven’t engaged you to teach in a Sunday school, - way have’ they?” = aed

“Do you think anyone would choose me to teach in Sunday school?”

“Not if they knew you well, certainly.”

ife is full ‘of trials, isn’t it?” said Anthony cheerfully. Mrs. Caldicott’s eyes gleamed, and she remarked with the air of one springing a mine, “I suspected as much, and in anticipation I poured off svme tea into a jug at breakfast ‘this morning! I can heat that up on the spirit lamp. Come, father.” Mr. and Mrs. Caldicott sailed off triumphantly to _ the hotel, the lady’s back complacent with successful thought.

Chapter Two

A Lady in Distress

“So that’s that,” said Anthony, finishing, off his glass and _ replacing it on the table. “What boat were you going on?”

“Granarth Castile.”

“Passage booked in your name, I suppose, so I’d better travel as James McGrath. We’ve outgrown the passport business, haven’t we?”

“No odds either way. You and I are totally unlike, but we’d probably have the same description on one of those blinking things. Height 6 feet, hair brown, eyes blue, nose, _

ordinary, chin ordinary— “Not so much of this ‘ordinary’ stunt. Let me tell you that Castle’s selected me out of several applicants solely - on account of my pleasing appearance and nice manners.” Jimmy grinned. “I noticed your manners this morning.” ee “The devil you did.” Anthony rose and paced up and down the room. His _ brow was slightly wrinkled, and it was some minutes before _ he spoke. “Jimmy,” he said at last. “Stylptitch died in Paris. What’s the point of sending a manuscript from Paris to : ona via Africa?”

Jimmy shook his head helplessly. “T don’t know.”

“Why not do it up in a nice little parcel and send it by post?”

“Sounds a damn sight more sensible, I agree.” “Of course,” continued Anthony, “I know that kings and queens and government officials are prevented by etiquette from doing anything in a simple, sha chee Nba fashion

“Yes,” said Anthony. “And it did for him too, poor beg-_ gar. She was some little guttersnipe of a music-hall artiste

in Paris—not even a suitable for a morganatic alliance. But

Nicholas had a frightful crush on her, and she was all out

for being a queen. Sounds fantastic, but they managed it somehow. Called her the Countess Popofisky, or something, _

and pretended she had Romanoff blood in her veins. NichoJas married her in the Cathedral at Ekarest with a couple of unwilling archbishops to do the job, and she was crowned —as Queen Varaga. Nicholas squared his ministers.

King’s Ring! Pass, my lord? nee usually it was 3 fe biker fellow who had stolen it, I always wonder why some bright lad never hit on the expedient of copying the ring—making a dozen or so, and selling them at a hundred ducats apiece. They seem to have had no initiative in the Middle Ages.”

Jimmy yawned.

“My remarks on the Middle Ages don’t seem to amuse you. Let us get back to Count Stylptitch. From France to England via Africa seems a bit thick even for a diplomatic personage. If he merely wanted to ensure that you should get a thousand pounds he could have left it to you in © his will. Thank God neither you nor I are too proud to accept a legacy! Stylptitch must have been balmy.”

“You’d think so, wouldn’t you?”

Anthony frowned and continued his pacing. “Have you read the thing at all?” he asked suddenly.

“Read what?”

“The manuscript.”

“Good lord, no. What do you think I want to wad a thing of that kind for?”

Anthony smiled. “I just wondered, that’s all. You know | a lot of trouble has been caused by memoirs. Indiscreet revelations, that sort of thing. People who have been close as an oyster all their lives seem positively to relish causing trouble when they themselves shall be comfortably dead. It gives them a kind of ‘malicious glee. Jimmy, what sort of a man was Count Stylptitch? You met him and talked to him, and you’ te a pretty good judge of raw human —. Could you imagine him being a vindictive old devil?”

Jimmy shook his head. “It’s difficult to tell. You see, that first night he was distinctly canned, and the next day he was just a high-toned old boy with the most beautiful manners overwhelming me with compliments till I didn’t know where to look.” “And he didn’t say anything interesting when he } drunk?” rf ‘Jimmy cast his mind back, wrinkling his brows as ae did. so. “He said he knew where the Kohinoor was,” be volunteered doubtfully.

“Oh, well,” said Anthony, “we all know that. They keep “You’re incurable, Jimmy. A thousand pounds in the hand is worth a lot of mythical gold.”

“And supposing it’s all a hoax? Anyway, here I am, passage booked and everything, on the way to Cape Town’ —and then you blow along!” . “Two hundred and fifty pounds free of income tax, as the saying goes?” ‘ “That’s it.”

t in the Tower, don't they? Behind thick plate glass and _ iron bars, with a lot of gentlemen in fancy dress standing round to see you don't pinch anything."

"That's right," agreed Jimmy.

"Did Stylptitch say anything else of the same kind? That he knew which city the Wallace Collection :was in, for instance?"

_ Jimmy shook his head. ; "H'm!" said Anthony. He lit another cigarette, and once. _ more began pacing up and down the room. "You never - read the papers, I suppose, you heathen?" he threw out presently. ! "Not very often," said McGrath simply. "They're not about anything that interests me as a rule."

"Thank heaven I'm more civilized. There have poe several mentions of Herzoslovakia lately. Hints at 4 royalist restoration."

"Nicholas IV didn't leave a son," said Jimmy. "But I don't suppose for a minute that the Obolovitch dynasty is extinct. There are probably shoals of young 'uns knocking _ about, cousins and second cousins and third cousins once _ removed." . "So that there would be any difficulty in finding a king?"

"Not in the least, I should say," replied Jimmy. "You _ know, I don't wonder at their getting tired of republican _ institutions. A full-blooded, virile people like that must find it awfully tame to pot at presidents after being used to _ kings. And talking of kings, that reminds me of something else old Stylptitch let out that night. He said he knew the g gang that was after him, They were King Victor's bt _ ple, he said." hewn What?" Anthony wheeled round suddenly. A slow grin widened on McGrath's face. "Just a mite excited, aren't you, Gentleman Joe?" he drawled. . i "Don't be an ass, Jimmy. You've just said something . father important." He went over to the window and stood

"I don't know," said Anthony. "It doesn't seem likely on the face of it. King Victor never stole the crown jewels of Herzoslovakia as far as I've heard. But the whole thing seems rather suggestive, doesn't it? The death of Stylptitch, the memoirs, and the rumors in the papers—all vague but interesting. And there's a further rumor to the effect that | they've found oil in Herzoslovakia. I've a feeling in my bones, James, that people are getting ready to be interested in that unimportant little country."

The job for four years or so. It would quite amuse me to - govern a kingdom like Herzoslovakia for four years." ? "The average for kings is even less, I should say," interpolated Jimmy. "It will probably be a serious temptation to me to embezzle your share of the thousand pounds. You won't want it, you know, when you get back weighed down with nuggets. I'll invest it for you in Herzoslovakian oil shares. You 3 _ know, James, the more I think of it, the more pleased I - am with this idea of yours. I should never have thought of _ Herzoslovakia if you hadn't mentioned it. I shall spend - one day in London, collecting the booty, and then away by - the Balkan express!" "You won't get off quite as fast as that. I didn't mention _ it before, but I've got another little commission for you." Anthony sank into a chair and eyed him severely. "I knew all along that you were keeping something dark. _ This is where the catch comes in." "Not a bit. It's just something that's got to be done to help a lady." "Once and for all, James, I refuse to be mixed up in your beastly love affairs." "It's not a love affair. "ve never seen the woman, Ill tell you the whole story." "If I've got to listen to more of your long, rambling stories, I shall have to have another drink." His host complied hospitably with this demand, then began the tale. "It was when I was up in Uganda. There _ was a navvy there whose life I had saved— " "Tf I were you, Jimmy, I should write a short book entitled Lives T Have Saved. This is the second I've heard of - this evening." "Oh, well, I didn't really do anything this time. Just pulled the fellow out of the river. Like all navvies, he % _couldn't swim." ? "Wait a minute, has this ea anything to do with the _ other business?" __ "Nothing whatever, though, oddly enough, now I remember it, the man was. a Herzoslovakian. We always called im Dutch Pedro though."

"What sort of people?"

"Financiers in City offices."

"What are you driving at with all this?"

"Trying to make an easy job difficult; that's all."

"You can't pretend there's going to be any difficulty in handing over a simple manuscript at a publisher's office?" ‘

"No," said Anthony regretfully. "I don't suppose there'll be anything difficult about that. But shall I tell you, James, where I propose to go with my £250?"

Chapter Three

Anxiety in High Places

“Quite so, my dear fellow, quite so,” said Lord Caterham. He had used, the same words three times already, each time in the hope that they would end the interview and permit him to escape. He disliked very much being forced to stand on the steps of the exclusive London club to which he belonged and listen to the interminable eloquence of the Hon. George Lomax. = Clement Edward Alistair Brent, ninth Marquis of Caterham, was a small gentleman, shabbily dressed, and entirely unlike the popular conception of a marquis. He had She — blue eyes, a thin melancholy nose, and a vague beautiful manner. The principal misfortune of Lord Caterham’s life was, to have succeeded his brother, the eighth Marquis, years ago. For the previous Lord Caterham had been a man of mark, a household word all over England. At one — time Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs, he had always figured largely in the counsels of the Empire, and his country — try seat, Chimneys, was famous for its hospitality. Able to be seconded by his wife, a daughter of the Duke of Perth, his history had been made and unmade at informal week-end parties at Chimneys, and there was hardly a day of not at one time or another, stayed there. That was all very well. The ninth Marquis of Caterham brother. Henry had done that kind of thing magnificently.

What Lord Caterham objected to was the assumption that

he was bound to follow in his brother’s footsteps, and that Chimneys was a national possession rather than a private country house. There was nothing that bored Lord Caterham more than politics—unless it was politicians. Hence his impatience under the continued eloquence of George Lomax. A robust man, George Lomax, inclined to stoutness, with a red face and protuberant eyes, and an immense sense of his own importance.

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“You see the point, Caterham? We can’t—we simply can’t afford a scandal of any kind just now. The position — is one of the utmost delicacy.”

“It always is,” said Lord Caterham, with a flavor of irony.

“My dear fellow, I’m in a position to know!”

“Oh, quite so, quite so,” said Lord Caterham, falling back upon his previous line of defense.

“One slip over this Herzoslovakian business and we’re done. It is most important that the oil concessions should be granted to a British company. You must see that?”

“Of course, of course.”

“Prince Michael Obolovitch arrives the end of the week, and the whole thing can be carried through at Chimneys under the guise of a shooting-party. 2

“I was thinking of going abroad this week,” said Lord — Caterham.

“Nonsense, my dear — because no one goes abroad in early October.” — “My doctor seems to think I’m in rather a bad way,”

said Lord Caterham, eyeing a taxi that was crawling past with longing eyes. He was quite unable to make a dash for liberty, however, since Lomax had the unpleasant habit of retaining a hold upon a person with whom he was engaged in serious conversation—doubtless the result of long — use. In this case, he had a firm grip of the lapel of — Lord Caterham’s coat. “My dear man, I put it to you imperially. In a moment of — national crisis, such as is fast approaching—”

Lord Caterham wriggled uneasily. He felt suddenly that he would rather give any number of house parties than

listen to George Lomax quoting from one of his own — speeches. He knew by experience that Lomax was quite capable of going on for twenty minutes without a stop. “All right,” he said hastily, “I’ll do it. You’ll arrange the whole thing, I suppose.” “My dear fellow, there’s nothing to arrange associations, is ideally situated. A — wouldn’t do, of course, for me to be actually a — member of the house party.”

“The shooting, of course, is not really important. as only the pretext, as it were.’

Lord Caterham looked depressed again.

“That will be all, then. The Prince, his suite, Bill Eversleigh. Herman Isaacstein—”,

“Who?” i

“Herman Isaacstein. The fopteeeaatien of the syndicate — 1 spoke to you about.”

“The All British Syndicate?”

“Yes. Why?”

“Nothing—nothing—I only wondered, that’s all.”

“Then, of course, there ought to be one or two outsiders. just to give the thing a bona fide appearance. Lady EiJeen could see to that—young People, uncritical, and with no idea of poltics.” :
“Bundle would attend to that all right, I’m sure.”
“T wonder now.” Lomax seemed struck by an idea. “You remember the matter I was speaking about just now?”
“You’ve been speaking about so many things.”
“No, no, I mean this unfortunate contrete he lowered his voice to a mysterious whisper— “Memoirs » —Count Stylptitch’s memoirs.”
“TI think you’re wrong about that,” said Lord Caterham, ‘ suppressing a yawn. “People like scandal. Damn it all, I read reminiscences myself—and enjoy ’em too.”

_ “The point is not whether people will read them or not —they’ll read them fast enough—but their publication at this juncture might ruin everything—everything. The people of Herzoslovakia wish to restore the monarchy, and are prepared to offer the crown to Prince Michael who has the support of our Government— “And who is prepared to grant concessions to Isaacstein _ & Co. in return for the loan of a million or so to set him _ on the throne.

- “Caterham, Caterham,” implored Lomax in an agonized whisper. “Discretion, I beg of you. Above all things, discretion.”

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“And the point is,” continued Lord{ Caterham, with some relish, though he lowered his voice in obedience to the other’s appeal, “that some of Stylptitch’s reminis- . cences may upset the apple cart? Tyranny and misbehavior of the Obolovitch family generally, eh? Questions asked in the House. Why replace the present broad-minded and democratic form of government by an obsolete tyranny? Policy dictated by the blood-sucking capitalists. Down with the government. That kind of thing—eh?”

Lomax nodded. “And there might be worse still,” he

breathed. “Suppose—only suppose that some reference should be made to—to that unfortunate disappearance— you know what I mean.’

Lord Caterham stared at him. “No, I don’t. What disappearance?”

“You must have heard of it? Why, it happened while they were at Chimneys. Henry was terribly upset about it.

_ It almost ruined his career.”

Chapter four

A Very Charming Lady

George Lomax returned straightway to Whitehail. As he entered the sumptuous apartment in which he transacted affairs of state, there was a scuffling sound. Mr. Bill Eversleigh was assiduously filing letters, but a large armchair near the window was still warm from contact with a human form. A very likable young man, Bill Eversleigh. Age at a guess, 25, big and rather ungainly in his movements, a pleasantly ugly face, a splendid set of white teeth and a pair of honest brown eyes.

“Richardson sent up that report yet?” =

“No, sir. Shall I get on to him about it?”

“It doesn’t matter. Any telephone messages?”

“Miss Oscar is dealing with most of them. Mr. Isaacstein wants to know if you can dine with him at the Seem tomorrow.”

“Tell Miss Oscar to look in my engagement book. If I’m not engaged, she can ring up and accept.” said he: “Yes, sir.” , so he said — “By the way, Eversleigh, you might ring up a number for me now. Look it up in the books Mrs. Revel, 487 Font Street.”

“Yes, sir.” Bill seized the telephone book, ran an unseeing eye down a column of names, shut the book with a bang, and moved to the instrument on the desk. With his

hand upon it, he paused, as though in sudden recollection. “Oh, I say, sir, I’ve just remembered. Her line’s out of order. Mrs. Revel’s, I mean. I was trying to ring her up just now.”

George Lomax frowned. “Annoying,” he said, “distinctly annoying.” He tapped the

table undecidedly.

“If it’s anything important, sir, perhaps, I might go round ~ there now in a taxi. She’s sure to be in at this time in the morning.”

George Lomax hesitated, pondering the matter. Bill waited expectantly, poised for instant flight, should the reply be favorable. “Perhaps that would be the best plan,” said Lomax at last. “Very well, then take a taxi there and ask Mrs. Revel if she will be at home this afternoon at four o’clock as I am very anxious to see her about an important matter.”

“Right sir.” Bill seized his hat and departed. Ten minutes later a taxi deposited him at 487 Pont Street. He rang the bell and executed a loud rat-tat on the knocker. The door was opened by a grave functionary to whom Bill nodded with the ease of long acquaintance.

“Morning, Chilvers. Mrs. Revel in?” ~

“I believe, sir, that she is just going out.”

“Is that you, Bill?” called a voice over the banisters. “I thought I recognized that muscular knock. Come up and talk to me.” ;

Bill looked up at the face that was laughing down on him, and which was always inclined to reduce him—and

- not him alone—to a state of babbling incoherency. He took

the stairs two at a time and clasped Virginia Revel’s outstretched hands tightly in his. “Hullo, Virginia!” — “Hullo, Bill!” ‘Charm is a very peculiar thing; hundreds of young women, some of them more beautiful than Virginia Revel, “all have said “Hullo, Bill,” with exactly the same intonation, and yet have produced no effect whatever. But those two simple words, uttered by Virginia, had the most intoxicating effect upon Bill. A delightful creature,” murmured Lord Caterham, “That is settled, then.” Mr. Lomax relaxed his hold on Lord Caterham’s lapel, and the latter was quick to avail himself of the chance. “By-by, Lomax, you’ll make all the arrangements, won’t you?” He dived into a taxi. As far as it is possible for one upright another upright Christian

Virginia Revel was just 27. She was tall and of an exquisite slimness—indeed, a poem might have been written to her slimness, it was so exquisitely proportioned. Her hair was of real bronze, with a greenish tint in its gold; she had a determined little chin, a lovely nose, slanting blue eyes that showed a gleam of deepest cornflower between the half-closed lids, and a delicious and quite indescribable mouth that tilted ever so slightly at one corner in what is known as “the signature of Venus.” It was a wonderfully expressive face, and there was a sort of radiant vitality about her that always challenged attention. It would have been quite impossible ever to ignore Virginia Revel. She drew Bill into the small drawing room which was all pale and mauve and green and yellow, like crocuses surprised in a meadow.

“Bill, darling,” said Virginia, “isn’t the Foreign Office missing you? I thought they couldn’t get on without you.”

“I’ve brought a message for you from Codders.” Thus irreverently did Bill allude to his chief. “And by the way, Virginia, in case he asks, remember that your aa gin was out of order this morning.”

“But it hasn’t been.”

“TI know that. But I said it was.”

“Why? Enlighten me as to this Foreign Office touch.”

Bill threw her a reproachful glance. “So that I could get here and see you, of course.”

“Oh, darling Bill, how dense of me! And how perfectly sweet of you!”

“Chilvers said you were going out.”

“So I was—to Sloane Street. Give me George’ S message.”

“He wants to know whether you’ll be in at four o ork this afternoon.”

“T shan’t. I shall be at Ranelagh. Why this sort of foniisal call? Is he going to propose to me, do you think?”

“T shouldn’t wonder.” :

“Because, if so, you can tell him that I much prefer men aa who propose on impulse.”

“Like me?”

‘ “It’s not an Scoulee with you, Bill. It’s habit. ste

“Virginia, won’t you ever—”

“No, no, no, Bill. I won’t have it in the morning before lunch. Do try and think of me as a nice motherly person approaching middle age hin has your interests thoroughly at heart.”

Virginia, I do love you so.”

“I know, Bill, I know. And I simply love being loved. Isn’t it wicked and dreadful of me? I should like every nice man in the world to be in love with me.”

“Most of them are, I expect,” said Bill gloomily.

“But I hope George isn’t in love with me. I don’t think ~ he can be. He’s so wedded to his career. What else did he say?”

“Just that it was very ienporant,”“Bill, I’m getting intrigued. The things that George thinks important are so awfully limited. I think I must chuck Ranelagh. After all, I can go to Ranelagh any day. Tell George that I shall be awaiting him meekly at four o’clock.”Bill looked at his wrist watch. “It seems hardly worth _ while to go back before lunch, Come out and chew some~~ thing, Virginia.

“I’m going out to lunch somewhere or other.”

“That doesn’t matter. Make a day of it, and chuck everything all round.”

“It would be rather nice,” said Virginia, smiling at him,

“Virginia, you’re a darling. Tell me, you do like me rather, don’t you? Better than other people.”

“Bill, I adore you. If I had to marry someone—simply had to—I mean if a wicked mandarin said to me ‘Marry ‘someone or die by slow torture,’ I should choose you at once—I should indeed.”

“Well, then”

“Yes, but I haven’t got to marry anyone, I love panne a wicked widow.”

“You could do all the same. things still. Go about, and that. You’d hardly notice me about the house.” ,

“Bill, you don’t understand. I’m the ikind mrs person. tahoe marries enthusiastically if they marry at all.”

Bill gave a hollow groan. “I shall shoot myself one of these days, I expect,” he murmured gloomily.

“No, you won’t, Bill, darling. You’ll take a pretty girl out to supper—tlike you did the night before last.”

Mr. Eversleigh was momentarily confused. “If you mean Dorothy Kirkpatrick, the girl who’s in Hooks and Eyes, \— well, dash it all, she’s a thoroughly nice girl, straight as they make ’em. There was no harm. in it.”

“Bill, darling, of course there wasn’t. I love you to enjoy yourself. But don’t pretend to be dying of a broken heart, that’s a

Mr. Eversleigh recovered his dignity. I know they are.

Chapter Five

First Night in London

There is often a flaw in the best-laid plans. George Lomax “had made one mistake—there was a weak spot in his preparations. The weak spot was Bill.

Bill Eversleigh was an extremely nice lad. He was a good cricketer and a scratch golfer, he had pleasant manners, and an amiable disposition, but his position in the Foreign Office had been gained, not by brains, but by good — connections. For the work he had to do he was quite suitable. He was more or less George’s dog. He did no responsible or brainy work. His part was to be constantly at George’s elbow, to interview unimportant people whom George didn’t want to see, to run errands, and generally to make himself useful. All this Bill carried out faithfully enough. When George was absent, Bill stretched himself out in the biggest chair and read the sporting news, and in so doing he was merely carrying out a time-honored tradition. Being accustomed to send Bill on errands, George had dispatched him to the Union Castle offices to find out when the Granarth Castle was due in. Now, in common with most well-educated young Englishmen, Bill had a pleasant, but quite inaudible voice. Any elocution master would have found fault with his pronunciation of the word Granarth. It might have been anything; The clerk took it to be Carnfrae. The Carnfrae Castle was due in on the following Thursday. He said so. Bill thanked him and went out. George Lomax accepted the information and laid his plans accordingly. He knew nothing about Union Castle liners, and took it for granted that James McGrath would duly arrive on Thursday.

Therefore, at the moment he was buttonholing Lord Caterham on the steps of the club on Wednesday morning, he would have been greatly surprised to learn that the Granarth Castle had docked at Southampton the preceding afternoon. At two o’clock that afternoon Anthony Cade, traveling under the name of Jimmy McGrath, stepped out of the boat train at Waterloo, hailed a taxi, and after a moment’s hesitation ordered the driver to proceed to the Blitz Hotel. “One might as well be comfortable,” said Anthony to himself, as he looked with some interest out of the taxi windows. It was fourteen years since he had been in London.

He arrived at the hotel, booked a room, and then went for a short stroll along the Embankment. It was rather pleasant to be back in London again, Everything was changed of course. There had been a little restaurant there —just past Blackfriars Bridge—where he had dined fairly often, in company with other earnest lads.

He retraced his steps back to the Blitz. Just as he was crossing the road, a man jostled against him, nearly making him lose his balance. They both recovered themselves, and the man muttered an apology, his eyes scanning Anthony’s face narrowly. He was a short, thickset man of the working classes, with something foreign in his appearance. Bhehony went on into the hotel, wondering as he did so what had inspired that searching glance. Nothing in it probably. The deep tan of his face was somewhat unusual-looking among these pallid Londoners and it had attracted the fellow’s attention. He went up to his room and, led by a sudden impulse, crossed to the looking-glass and stood studying his face in it. Of the few friends of the old days—just a chosen few—was it likely that any of them would recognize him now if they were to meet him face-to face? He shook his head. When he had left London he had been just eighteen—a fair, slightly chubby boy, with a misleading seraphic expression. Small chance that the boy would be recognized in the brown-faced man with the quizzical expression.

The telephone beside the bed rang, and Anthony crossed to the receiver. “Hullo!” : The voice of the desk clerk answered him. “Mr. James McGrath?” E “Speaking.”

“A gentleman has called to see you.”

Anthony was rather astonished. “To see me?”

“Yes sir, a foreign gentleman.”

“What’s his name?”

There was a slight pause, and then the clerk said, “I will send up a page boy with his card.” Anthony replaced the receiver and waited. In a few minutes there was a knock on the door and a small page appeared bearing a card upon a salver. Anthony took it. The following was the name engraved upon it: Baron Lolopretizyl.

He now fully interpreted the desk clerk’s pause. For a moment or two he stood studying the card, and then made up his mind, “Show the gentleman up.” “Very good, sir.” In a few minutes the Baron Lolopretizyl was ushered into the room, a big man with an immense fan-like black beard and a high, bald forehead. He brought his heels together with a click, and bowed. “Mr. McGrath,” he said,

Anthony imitated his movements as nearly as possible.

“That is so,” agreed the Baron, seating himself. “It is my misfortune,” he added politely.

“And mine also,” responded Anthony, on the same note.

“Let us now to business come,” said the Baron. “TI Tepresent in London the Loyalist party of Herzoslovakia.”

_ “And represent it be eg I am sure,” murmured Anthony.

The Baron bowed in dcknswled enact of the compliment, “You are too kind,” he said stiffly. “Mr. McGrath, I will not from you conceal anything. The moment has come for the restoration of the monarchy, in abeyance since the martyrdom of His Most Gracious Majesty King Nicholas IV of blessed memory.”

“Amen,” murmured Anthony. “I mean hear, hear.”

_ “On the thone will be placed His Highness Prince Michael who the support of the British Government has.”

“Spendid,” said Anthony. “It’s very kind of you to tell me all this.”

“Everything arranged is—when you come here to trouble make.” The Baron fixed him with a stern eye.

“My dear Baron,” protested Anthony.

“Yes, yes, I know what I talking about. You have with you the memoirs of the late Count Stylptitch.” He fixed Anthony with an accusing eye.“And if I have? What have the memoirs of Count Stylptitch to do with Prince Michael?”

“They will cause scandals.”

“Most memoirs do that,” said Anthony soothingly. “Of many secrets he the knowledge had. Should he re-

veal but the quarter of them, Europe into war plunged may be.”

“Come, come,” said Anthony. “It can’t be as bad as all that.”

“An unfavorable opinion of the Obolovitch will abroad be spread. So democratic is the English spirit.”

You do not colony said the Baron. wy oat understand at all. And my lips sealed are.” He si

“What exactly are you afraid of?” asked Anthony,

“Until I have read the memoirs I do not kino” Cex plained the Baron simply. “But there is sure to be something. These great diplomats are always indiscreet. The apple cart upset will be, as the saying goes.”

“Look here,” said Anthony kindly. “I’m sure you’r re taking altogether too pessimistic a view of the thing. I know all about publishers—they -sit on manuscripts_and hatch ’em like eggs. It will be at least a year before ae thing is published.” :

“Bither a very deceitful or a very simple young man ~ you are. All is arranged for the memoirs in a Sunday newspaper to come out immediately.” :

“Oh!” Anthony was somewhat taken aback. “But you — can always deny everything,” he said hopefully.

The Baron shook his head sadly. “No, no, through the hat you talk. Let us to business come. One thousand pounds you are to have, is it not so? You see, I have the good information got.” Se“I certainty congratulate the intelligence department of the Loyalists.” “Then I to you offer fifteen hundred.”

Anthony stared at him in amazement, then shook: his head ruefully. “I’m afraid it can’t be done,” he said, with regret. i “Good. I to you-offer two thousand.” Pi “You tempt me, Baron, you tempt me. But I still aay it can’t be done.” (eaen “Your own price name, then.” “Ym afraid you don’t understand the position. rm perfectly willing to believe that you are on the side of the , angels, and that these memoirs may damage your cause. Nevertheless, I’ve undertaken the job, and I’ve — got to. carry it through. See? I can’t allow myself to be bous ie:

thony’s speech ihe nodded his wo several times. Your honor as an English gentleman it is?”